

DIPLOMA IN MODERN APPLIED PSYCHOLOGY



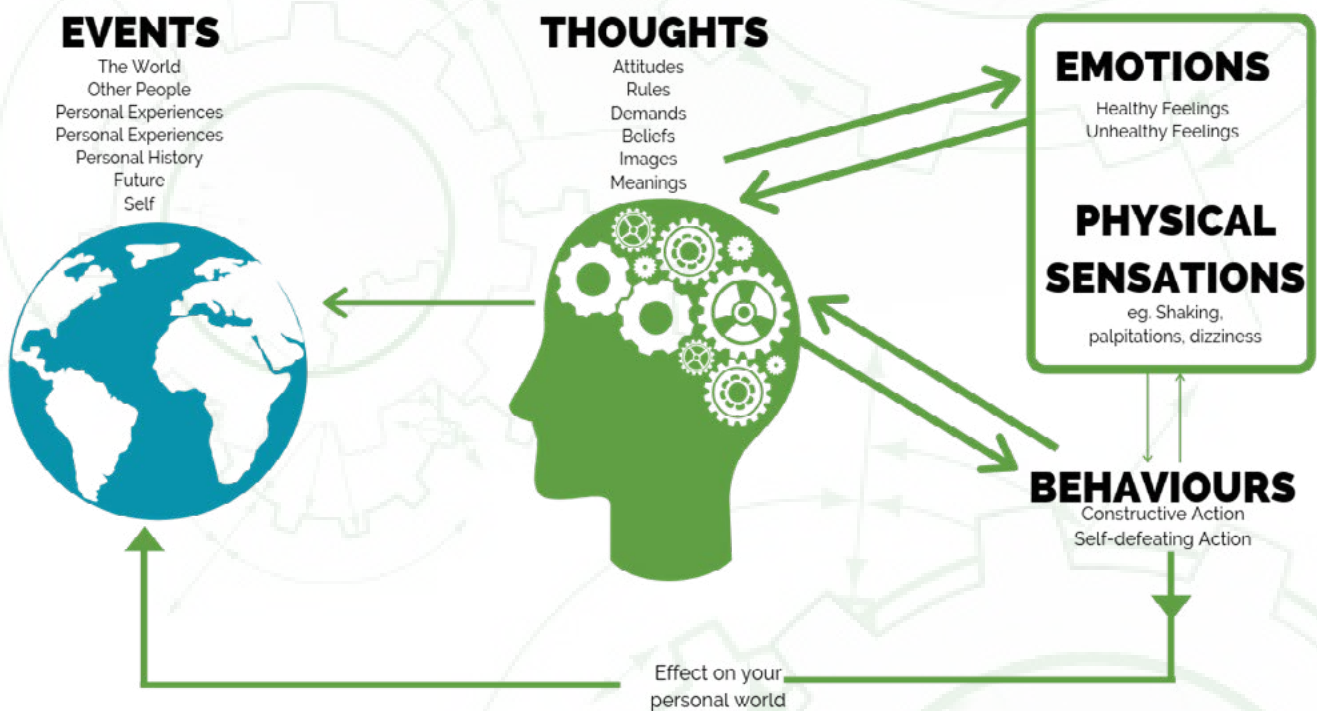
**THE HUMAN
EXPERIENTIAL MODEL**

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Where some theories do a great job helping us understand some areas of the human experience, such as CAT, CFT, DBT etc, this cognitive method offers a more holistic approach by exploring the way our thoughts, feelings and physical sensations are connected. The scope of investigation allows for an individual to put more of the self-evaluation puzzle pieces together, ultimately bringing to light the role they play in their behaviour and outcomes.

It's the nature of human interaction that we find it very easy to identify disruptive and unhelpful outputs. This is because we all have personal responses to particular behaviours and characteristics, so we can identify people who are too loud, obnoxious, have an anxiety problem or anger issues. However, some outputs such as depression, eating disorders or stress aren't as clear cut to identify, so we use what we call 'outputs'. Outputs are not assumptions, they are the attitudes and actions a person discloses to you through the time you spend together.

As we discussed in the lecture, outputs are the range of projections an individual makes which include temperaments, behaviours, reactions, attitudes and reactions. As illustrated by the diagram below, our outputs do not exist in isolation - they're all outcomes of a cognitive process. Our experiences in life (i.e. our inputs) determine our self-evaluations and self-value, which in turn subconsciously dictate our outputs.



This model not only maps out the human psyche in a way we can fully appreciate its complexity, but it also details how we are able to unpack and gain a better insight into how individuals interpret their life experiences. In order to understand our outputs, it's essential that we first identify the inputs which impacted and determined them.

Everyone, at one point in life, behaves in a way which totally contradicts their values and desires for reasons they can't easily comprehend; for example, you may have experienced binge eating after a great day of dieting and exercise, or you may have been attracted to the kinds of people you have had bad experiences of in the past. Despite us wanting other, more fulfilling things in life, we do things which produce outcomes paradoxical to our ambitions and dreams.

It's important to remember that we don't arrive at conclusions about our lovability or value without external input. Our perceptions of ourselves have been garnered through years



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of experiences, and because of those experiences, we have adopted reactionary coping mechanisms which we use for similar or related scenarios. Someone may have an anger complex and aggressively refute criticism because of personal experience of having been put down by key figures in their life, or they may struggle to find self-worth in the world outside of an academic system where they once thrived and prospered.

We cannot undo the inputs we've received over the years, but it doesn't make us helpless victims to the effects they've had on our self-image. The beauty of this model is that it shows us that our bad and destructive behaviours can be addressed and unlearned, provided we take full responsibility and control of the choices we make.

A = B (External World = Our Thoughts):

How we respond to the external world determines how our internal world operates. The beliefs most of us operate out of aren't well-informed, wise conclusions we've arrived to on our own merit, but are usually reflective of the ideologies we grew up in (i.e. the ideologies of our families, society and culture).

Our attitudes, beliefs, demands, images, meanings and rules serve as our filters: they determine how we emotionally respond to our external circumstances (C).

Healthy and unhealthy emotions reflect the quality of our thoughts. Our unhealthy emotions inform us of our unhealthy cognitive processes and the unhealthy ways we've interpreted our experiences. Maturity reflects one's ability to regulate their thoughts and emotional responses.

As we've discussed many times, our emotions go onto triggering and determining our behaviour. Whether our responses are constructive or destructive, our reactions will impact the external world and this, in turn, affects our internal monologue. We can only stop this cycle if we consciously choose to filter and monitor our thoughts and control the emotions and behaviours we enact. If we don't like what we're seeing in the external and internal world, we must change our patterns of internal processing.

Below is a breakdown of all the most common forms of input which affect our self-worth and ultimately our behaviours.

Performance Accomplishments

Many people assign their self-worth and value to their performance and accomplishments. This can be in institutions such as school, their career, or higher education, or even their "successful" interactions with other people. They rely on external, quantifiable evidence such as verbal or written feedback to value their worth in the world, only believing themselves to be intelligent if their grades reflect as such, or a good person if they're surrounded by other people.

This self-evaluation method is extremely black and white, as it fails to disassociate our accomplishments from ourselves as individuals. Every win and failure in life is considered not as an external product of circumstance, but as a personal comment about our status in the world and who we truly are. Failure makes you a failure in life, or to do poorly at a task at work makes you a 'bad worker', etc.



Past experiences

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Whilst many people will have experienced a significant, traumatising event within the past few years of their life which has mentally scarred them in some way, ultimately affecting their behaviour, not all people will have such a prominent point of reference when it comes to understanding how their past has impacted them.

The effects of the past experiences, for the majority, are so subtle they're almost invisible. It's likely that how people treated them in the past was so second nature that they never recognised or realised something was at fault. For example, the experiences which happened to us earliest in life tend to be the ones which are most influential, but remain unquestioned in adulthood because as a child we knew nothing better, therefore grow up supposing we experienced life the way it was intended.

Purely down to the nature of exposure, our parental upbringing (or lack thereof) will have a significant impact on our esteem and consequent behaviours. Perhaps our parents weren't consistent or there for us as much as they should have been, or perhaps they had a narcissistic personality disorder you weren't aware of as a child. Or, perhaps school was a source of great distress for you; there may have been more manipulative bullying you weren't aware of from not just classmates but from teachers. What happens in our earliest years takes far deeper roots than we can anticipate.

Social Persuasion

As already explained in the video, social persuasion is much deeper than peer pressure; it's not about taking up a smoking habit in your early teens to join a friend group, or even dieting to try and be skinny and popular at school (or though not too far removed). Social persuasion looks at your reactionary relationship to group mentality, be that in organisational culture, religious following, fitness culture regime or company.

Many people who need approval seek it from others through conformity. There will be certain figures in society, be they an individual, religious or a corporate entity, which will speak louder and more assuredly than others. Those who speak the loudest attract those with low self-worth or those who are confused and uncertain about their life. Those who fall victim to social persuasion are waiting for someone else to instruct them through life; they tell them who to be and what to do, think, and say.

You may find that you will at times be subjected to this kind of thinking from a client who wishes for you to fix them and tell them what to do. If you identify this kind of behaviour, you can begin exploring with your client other cases of social persuasion they've been subjected to and help them identify the pattern.

Love and Affection

Whilst this seems like an obvious and almost cliché, love is important not to overlook. The amount of love and affection we receive drives us in life, as does the amount we give. If we grew up around people who made us feel unattractive, if we didn't receive unconditional love as a child from our parents, or were made to believe that we are incapable and undeserving of love, our ability to love ourselves and others will be detrimentally affected. This one factor can result in numerous defence mechanisms from aggression or emotional withdrawal to narcissistic tendencies to self-harm and depression.



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Evaluative feedback

Evaluative feedback is the narrative input you feed to your client as a modern applied psychologist (MAP). This is where a MAP employs a positive, role model influence on a client by being completely congruent and unconditionally accepting of them. By increasing a client's positive evaluative feedback, their negative, comparative feedback decreases. By employing the four core conditions we learn as a counsellor, we supply our client with a feedback which may, the grand scheme of things, seem small in comparison to a lifetime's worth of negative inputs; but for a client who has likely never had the permission in their life to fully be themselves, they can be enough to help them totally transform their perceptions of themselves.



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